Mustafa Alperen Ekinci

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Research: Scene processing, empirical aesthetics, visual perception, individual differences, deep neural networks, eye movements, EEG, fMRI

Education

Ph.D. in Cognitive Neuroscience — Germany
Neural Computation Group, Justus-Liebig-University Giessen — 2024–Current

- Supervisor: Prof. Daniel Kaiser
  Topic: "Resolving the Brain Dynamics Underlying Aesthetic Visual Experiences during Movie Watching"

M.Sc. in Neural and Behavioral Sciences — Germany
Max-Planck Institutes for Biological Cybernetics - The University of Tübingen — 2021–2023

- Supervisor: Prof. Andreas Bartels
  Thesis: "TrueScenometry: FMRI Responses to True Scene Geometry of Motion in Movies"

B.A. in Psychology — Turkey
Bogazici University — 2017–2021

- Supervisor: Prof. Inci Ayhan
  Thesis: "The Effects of Emotions on Time Perception"

Research Positions

University of Toronto - Visiting Scholar — Canada
With Prof. Dirk B.Walther and Prof. Oshin Vartanian — Sep - Dec 2026
Investigated the effects of gaze synchrony in a collective engagement task.

Max Planck Institute for Biological Cybernetics - Research Assistant — Germany
With Dr. Michael Bannert — Oct-Dec 2023
Investigated fMRI responses to the ground-truth optical flow representation of movies in the brain.

Max Planck Institute for Intelligent Systems - Research Assistant — Germany
With Prof. Michael Black — Dec 2021 - July 2023
Worked on 4D human motion capture using state-of-the-art motion capture techniques.

Michigan State University - Research Assistant — USA
With Prof. J. Devin McAuley — Jan - May 2020
Investigated mechanisms of rhythm processing in humans.

Skills

- **Programming:** Matlab, Python, jsPsych
- **Methods:** fMRI, EEG, eye tracker, online experiments
- **Analysis:** Decoding/encoding models of cognitive mechanisms, machine learning tools
- **Project management:** Leading independent end-to-end research projects, supervising thesis students

Teaching

- **Teaching Assistant** at JLU Giessen — Summer 2025
  Neural Computation II - Foundational neural computation methods in cognitive neuroscience II
- **Teaching Assistant** at JLU Giessen — Winter 2024
  Neural Computation I - Foundational neural computation methods in cognitive neuroscience I
- **Teaching Assistant** at Bogazici University — Spring 2021
  Introduction to Matlab

Supervision

- **Xueying Yan** Ongoing master's thesis: The role of aesthetic processing in multisensory integration.
- **Mark Merkouchev** Ongoing internship: The influence of predictability of an image in visual beauty.
- **Anastasiya Malamud** Ongoing internship: FMRI data collection for a multisensory integration experiment.
- **Melis Akdeniz** Master's thesis: The part-whole relationship in art perception.
- **Nina Buhlmann** Bachelor's thesis: Modeling aesthetic experiences across the viewing of an artistic film.

Awards

- **Poster award** at International Association of Empirical Aesthetics (IAEA) 2026
- **Travel award** at International Association of Empirical Aesthetics (IAEA) 2026
- **Young researcher award** from the Scientific and Technological Research Council of Türkiye (TÜBİTAK) 2021

Conferences

- Vision Sciences Society (VSS) 2026
- International Association of Empirical Aesthetics (IAEA) 2026
- Visual Science of Art Conference (VSAC) 2025
- European Conference on Visual Perception (ECVP) 2025

Publications

[1] **M. A. Ekinci**, N. Buhlmann, and D. Kaiser, "From pixels to pleasure: Visual features explain dynamic aesthetic experiences across distinct movie content", *bioRxiv*, pp. 2026–04, 2026.

[2] **M. A. Ekinci** and D. Kaiser. "Shared gaze reflects shared aesthetic experiences". Preprint. bioRxiv: 2026.01.30.702749. [Online]. Available: https://doi.org/10.64898/2026.01.30.702749.

[3] D. Alashan, D. Tanriverdi, **M. A. Ekinci**, and I. Ayhan, "The effects of abutting pattern motion and smooth pursuit eye movement on the visibility of low-contrast luminance-modulated target gratings", *Journal of Vision*, vol. 21, no. 9, pp. 2634–2634, 2021.

[4] D. Tanrıverdi, D. Alashan, **M. A. Ekinci**, and I. Ayhan, "The effect of target motion and smooth pursuit eye movement on the visibility of isoluminant target gratings", *Journal of Vision*, vol. 21, no. 9, pp. 2619–2619, 2021.